HQ was the most strongly held position. Once they had identified the main bunker, they would have known where the communication hub was and also the location of the four 3-inch (81.5 mm) mortars.

In the first half hour, as we have seen, the concentrated mortar fire (combined with RCLs) had destroyed the signals bunker and the mortar position of 2 Rajput. As mortar bombs continued to rain down, Major Gurdial Singh, from inside his bunker, scanned the area ahead of him and across the river for any Chinese activity. If the bombardment was a prelude to an attack, by now the Chinese should have been milling around on the opposite bank. However, while the mortars continued to fire with the same intensity from the slopes above, the north bank of the Nam Ka Chu was devoid of all movement. Gurdial now realized that the bulk of the mortar shells were targeting the two platoons deployed behind him flanking Battalion HQ. This could only mean one thing: 'My god, they are going to assault us from the back!'

Disregarding the shelling, Gurdial emerged from the bunker and ran along the communication trench to the Vickers machine gun position, yelling above the noise of the explosions that the attack would be coming the moment the shelling stopped. He told the Mahar gun crew to take the weapon and follow him as the attack was almost certainly going to come from the rear. He himself grabbed the heavy tripod and managed to position it outside, but unfortunately the machine gunners were too dazed to follow him.

Also on the move was the Intelligence officer, Lieutenant Bhup Singh, who like the 2IC had understood that the attack would be from the rear. He quickly sprinted up to Rikh's bunker, passing on the way the communications bunker where Mangat and the rest of the signal crew lay dead.

After a sixty-minute bombardment, the shelling abruptly stopped. Any doubts about the direction of the impending attack were quickly dispelled as whistles and bugles went off on the slopes above them. In a virtual repeat of the tactics used against Charlie and Bravo companies at Temporary and Log Bridge, the Chinese swarmed down. Subedar Ram Chander and Jemadar Biswas barely had time to get the men out of the bunkers when their respective platoons on either side of Battalion HQ were attacked by the Chinese. The three officers in the centre, Rikh, Gurucharan Bhatia and Bhup Singh, had positioned themselves around the rear entrance of the